

ENG 111 – Public Speaking

Lecture 6: Delivery

How to make your message sound,
look, and feel effective

Lecture roadmap

What is speech delivery?

Four delivery methods: manuscript, memorized, impromptu, extemporaneous

Voice: volume, pitch, rate, pauses, pronunciation and vocal variety

Nonverbal delivery: eye contact, facial expression, gestures, posture and movement

Managing nervousness

Practice: pair coaching, group performance and delivery diagnosis

Learning outcomes

By the end of class, you should be able to:

Explain why delivery matters even when content is good.

Distinguish manuscript, memorized, impromptu and extemporaneous delivery.

Use volume, pitch, rate and pauses intentionally.

Use eye contact, facial expression, gestures and posture appropriately.

Identify distracting delivery habits and give constructive feedback.

Deliver a short passage with clearer and more engaging delivery.

Warm-up: Same words, different meaning

Say aloud: “I didn’t say she took my phone.”

Now say it four ways, stressing a different word each time.

I didn’t say she took my phone.

I didn’t say she took my phone.

I didn’t say she took my phone.

I didn’t say she took my phone.

Ask: Did the implication change? Why?

What is delivery?

Delivery is the way a speaker presents a speech to an audience.

Good delivery helps the audience understand the message, stay engaged and trust the speaker.

Delivery includes verbal and nonverbal behavior.

Think of a speech as two layers:

WHAT you say = words, ideas, evidence and organization

HOW you say it = voice, face, eye contact, gestures, posture and movement

Strong delivery supports the message; distracting delivery competes with the message.

Why does delivery matter?

Effective delivery

- Makes important ideas noticeable
- Shows confidence and interest
- Helps listeners follow transitions
- Creates connection with the audience
- Can make complex information easier to process

Poor/distracting delivery

- Speaking too softly
- Reading every word from notes
- Very fast or very slow rate
- No eye contact
- Repeated fillers such as “um” and “like”
- Constant movement or repetitive gestures

Four methods of delivery

1. Manuscript: speech is written out and read or closely followed.
 2. Memorized: speech is learned word-for-word and delivered from memory.
 3. Impromptu: speaking with little or no preparation.
 4. Extemporaneous: carefully prepared and rehearsed, but delivered conversationally from brief notes.
- Important: Extemporaneous does NOT mean unprepared. It means prepared without memorizing every sentence.

Choosing the right delivery method

Manuscript / Memorized

Useful when exact wording matters

Formal statements may require a script

Memorization can sound stiff if over-rehearsed

Forgetting one line can disrupt memorized delivery

Impromptu / Extemporaneous

Useful for spontaneous questions and short responses

Extemporaneous is suitable for most classroom speeches

Allows adaptation to audience reactions

Brief notes support natural eye contact

Pair activity 1: Delivery method detective

TASK

Decide which delivery method fits each situation: university debate response, wedding speech, emergency announcement, class presentation on climate change, legal statement.

TIME

6 minutes

HOW

Pairs choose a method and give a reason. There can be more than one defensible answer if the reasoning is strong.

OUTPUT

Share one situation where your pair's choice could be debated.

Voice: the speaker's instrument

Your voice carries meaning beyond the dictionary meaning of words.

Five useful vocal dimensions:

- Volume – how loud or soft you speak

- Pitch – how high or low the voice sounds

- Rate – how quickly or slowly you speak

- Pauses – moments of silence

- Vocal variety – changing vocal features to avoid a flat delivery

Goal: make vocal choices serve meaning, not simply make the speech dramatic.

Volume: be heard, not shouted

Volume should fit the room, audience size and purpose.

Too soft → listeners struggle to hear.

Too loud → can sound aggressive or uncomfortable.

Do not confuse volume with confidence.

Practical tip: aim your voice toward the back of the room rather than simply increasing loudness.

Check: Can the last person in the room understand every important word?

Pair activity 2: Volume check

TASK

Practice the same 2–3 sentence message at three levels: too soft, appropriate and too loud.

TIME

5 minutes

HOW

Partner sits several feet away and gives feedback: “Could I hear every word?”
Switch roles, then repeat using an appropriate classroom volume.

OUTPUT

Each student identifies one volume adjustment for future speaking.

Pitch and vocal variety

Pitch refers to how high or low your voice sounds.

Pitch naturally changes when we ask questions, show surprise, emphasize an idea or express emotion.

A completely flat pitch can make an interesting topic sound dull.

Constant dramatic changes can sound artificial.

Use variation around important ideas rather than changing pitch randomly.

Example: “We have a problem. But we also have a choice.” Pause and emphasize “problem” and “choice.”

Rate: slow down to help listeners think

Rate = speed of speaking.

Too fast: words blur together and the audience has less time to process information.

Too slow: listeners may lose momentum.

- Use a slower rate for definitions, important claims and emotional moments.

- Use a slightly faster rate for excitement, stories or less important background.

Practice: mark [SLOW] beside key ideas in your notes.

Pauses: silence can be powerful

A pause is not automatically a mistake.

Use a short pause:

- before an important point

- after an important point

- between major ideas

- after asking a question

- when you need a moment to think

Example: “There is one thing we cannot replace... [pause] ...time.”

Avoid filling every silence with “um,” “uh,” “so,” or “like.”

Pair activity 3: Pause for impact

TASK

Make this sentence more effective by adding pauses and emphasis: “If we want students to succeed we need to change the way we think about failure.”

TIME

6 minutes

HOW

Read it normally. Then add one or two pauses and stress key words. Partner explains which version was clearer and why. Switch.

OUTPUT

One final delivery using intentional pause + emphasis.

Pronunciation and articulation

Pronunciation = producing words in a way listeners can recognize.

Articulation = producing speech sounds clearly.

Good public speaking does not require a particular accent.

Clarity matters more than trying to erase your natural accent.

Helpful habits:

- Open your mouth enough to form sounds clearly.

- Do not swallow word endings.

- Slow down when a word or sentence is difficult.

- Practice unfamiliar names and technical terms before speaking.

- Avoid mumbling.

Fillers and verbal habits

Common fillers: “um,” “uh,” “like,” “you know,” “basically,” “actually,” “so...”

Repeated fillers can distract the audience.

Fillers often appear because the speaker is thinking, nervous or afraid of silence.

Better strategy: pause, breathe, then continue.

Practice: record a 30-second response and count fillers. Repeat and try to reduce them—not necessarily eliminate every single one.

Nonverbal delivery

Nonverbal delivery is communication through behavior rather than words.

Key elements:

- Eye contact

- Facial expression

- Gestures

- Posture

- Movement

- Appearance and use of space

Nonverbal behavior should support the message rather than become the message.

Eye contact: connect, don't stare

Eye contact helps create a sense of direct communication.

Look at different parts of the audience rather than speaking to only one person.

Hold eye contact long enough to complete a thought, then naturally move to another listener.

Do not continuously look at the floor, screen, ceiling or notes.

For a large room, divide the audience into sections and move your attention among them.

Tip: look at people while saying the idea—not only after saying it.

Group activity 1: Eye-contact triangle

TASK

Practice speaking while distributing eye contact.

TIME

8 minutes

HOW

Groups of 3: Speaker, Listener A and Listener B. Speaker gives a 45-second answer to “What is one change you would make at university?” Listeners track whether eye contact is balanced. Rotate roles.

OUTPUT

Each speaker receives one strength and one specific improvement.

Facial expression

Your face can reinforce or contradict your words.

Match expression to the meaning of the message.

Example: saying “This was a terrible experience” while smiling may confuse the audience.

Neutral does not mean expressionless.

Practice: deliver one sentence as excited, concerned, surprised and serious. Notice how expression changes interpretation.

Gestures: make them purposeful

Gestures can emphasize, describe size/direction, show contrast or help structure ideas.

Natural gestures are usually better than memorized hand movements.

Avoid repetitive habits: constant pointing, hair touching, pen clicking or hiding both hands in pockets.

Keep gestures within a comfortable range.

Gesture can support structure: when you say “three reasons,” a clear three-point gesture can help the audience follow.

Posture and movement

Stand in a balanced, comfortable position.

Good posture supports breathing and vocal projection.

Avoid locking your knees, rocking repeatedly or leaning on a desk.

Movement should have a reason.

Move when you transition between ideas, address another section of the audience or change the visual focus.

Do not pace continuously: repeated movement becomes a distraction.

Group activity 2: Delivery diagnosis

TASK

Identify what is helping and hurting delivery in a short performance.

TIME

10 minutes

HOW

Groups of 4. One student gives a 60-second mini-speech. Three observers focus on Voice, Eye contact and Gestures/Posture. Each observer writes ONE effective behavior and ONE distracting behavior. Speaker chooses one change and repeats the opening 20 seconds.

OUTPUT

Compare before/after: what changed when one delivery behavior was improved?

Managing nervousness

Feeling nervous before speaking is common. The goal is not to become completely emotionless.

Useful strategies:

- Prepare and rehearse the opening lines.

- Know your main points rather than memorizing every sentence.

- Take a slow breath before beginning.

- Start slightly slower than your nervous instinct tells you.

- Focus on communicating with the audience, not judging yourself.

- Use brief notes instead of reading a full script when appropriate.

Nervous energy can become useful energy when controlled.

Pair activity 4: Nervousness reset

TASK

Create a 20-second pre-speech routine.

TIME

4 minutes

HOW

Design and practise: posture reset → slow breath → first sentence → eye contact → begin. Discuss which step helps most.

OUTPUT

Write your personal 5-step pre-speech routine.

Delivery feedback: be specific

Avoid: “You were bad,” “You need confidence,” or “Speak better.”

Useful feedback identifies a visible behavior and its effect.

Formula: “When you ____, it helped/made it harder for me to ____.”

“When you paused before your main point, the idea became easier to notice.”

“You looked at the left side most of the time, so the right side felt less included.”

“Your rate increased near the end, so some words became difficult to catch.”

Mini delivery checklist

Before speaking, ask:

Can everyone hear me?

Am I speaking too fast?

Where are my key points?

Where will I pause?

Am I looking at the audience?

Are my gestures helping?

Am I standing comfortably?

Do my voice and facial expression match my message?

Final performance: 60-second delivery challenge

TASK

Deliver: “One communication habit every university student should develop.”

TIME

12–15 minutes

HOW

Prepare 3 points in 2 minutes. Deliver for 60 seconds using extemporaneous delivery. Audience scores voice, eye contact, gestures/posture, and pauses/rate. Repeat one part after feedback.

OUTPUT

Goal: show one visible improvement between the first and second delivery.

Exit ticket

1. What is the difference between impromptu and extemporaneous delivery?
2. Name two vocal techniques that can make an important point stand out.
3. What is one nonverbal habit you personally need to improve?
4. Why can a pause be more effective than a filler?
5. Write one specific delivery goal for your next speech.

Key takeaways

Delivery is not decoration—it affects how the audience receives the message.

Good delivery is clear, purposeful and audience-centered.

Use voice strategically: volume, pitch, rate, pauses and vocal variety.

Use nonverbal communication strategically: eye contact, facial expression, gestures, posture and movement.

Extemporaneous delivery combines preparation with a natural speaking style.

Practice + specific feedback + a second attempt = improvement.

Next class: Mid-Term Exam. Review the material covered so far.